

World in Brief: Huge earthquakes hit Venezuela; SK Hynix plans an IPO



Photograph: AFP

Two big **earthquakes** struck **Venezuela**, killing at least 32 people and injuring 700 more. There is a 44% chance that the death toll will surpass 10,000, according to the US Geological Survey. Delcy Rodríguez, [Venezuela's](#) acting president, declared a state of emergency. America said it was sending search and rescue teams. Electricity and telecom networks are down in parts of the country.

SK Hynix, the world's second-largest memory-chip maker, said it was looking to raise up to \$29.4bn on America's Nasdaq exchange. This week the tech giant briefly overtook [Samsung Electronics](#) as South Korea's most valuable company. Its listing could exceed the \$25.6bn raised by Saudi Aramco's initial public offering in 2019, a record until [SpaceX's \\$75bn IPO](#). SK Hynix's shares rose by as much as 12% after its announcement.

Meanwhile **Micron**, an American memory-chip maker, reported third-quarter revenue of \$41.5bn, up from \$9.3bn during the same period a year ago. Its profits surged nearly 15-fold, to \$28.2bn. The company's share price has soared by more than 700% in the past year, thanks to the AI boom. Micron's results come during a volatile week for markets, as investors have fretted about the value of AI stocks.

A federal judge blocked Donald Trump's attempt to force people to prove they are citizens when registering to vote. Several states have sued the president over an executive order seeking to change **election rules**. Mr Trump is separately pressuring the Senate to pass a bill containing that requirement, and another demanding that voters bring [photo identification](#) to cast a ballot.

Anthropic told America's Congress that **Alibaba** had been responsible for the "largest campaign to illicitly extract Claude's capabilities" ever. It accused the Chinese e-commerce giant of generating almost 29m exchanges with its AI model in order to copy [the lab's technology](#) for the benefit of China's armed forces. Alibaba is suing the American government after it blacklisted the firm and prevented the Pentagon from buying its products.

Israel said it would maintain its military presence in **southern Lebanon**. [The two countries](#) are negotiating an American-backed plan under which Israeli forces would cede parts of the territory they control to Lebanon's army. Iran has demanded that Israel end its campaign against Hizbullah, a militia backed by the Islamic regime, as part of its tentative peace deal with America.

Britain recorded its **hottest** ever temperature in June, reaching 36.1°C in southern England, as Europe swelters under [record-breaking temperatures](#). France suffered its hottest day on record for a second consecutive day. The number of deaths by drowning in France over the past week reached 48, as people take refuge from the heat. Schools across Europe have shut and travel has been severely disrupted.

Figure of the day: \$3trn, the estimated amount that will go into AI data centres globally between 2026 and 2030. But [opposition is also spreading](#).

Correction: A previous edition of the World in Brief stated that SK Hynix was the world's second-largest chipmaker. It is the world's

second-large memory-chip maker. Sorry.

US in Brief: Trump delays housing bill



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump cancelled plans to sign a big housing package into law until senators pass the **SAVE America Act**, which would require proof of citizenship to register to vote and [photo identification](#) to cast a ballot. Mike Johnson, the Republican speaker of the House, said Republicans would try to pass the measure through a budget-reconciliation bill, bypassing the Senate filibuster. Separately, a federal judge barred Mr Trump from enforcing an executive order seeking to change election rules.

Mr Trump reportedly clashed with **Republican Senators** when a meeting about the **SAVE America Act** veered into questions about the [Iran war](#). One heated exchange was said to involve Senator [Bill Cassidy](#) of Louisiana, who lost his primary after falling out with the president. Mr Cassidy was one of four Republicans who voted on Tuesday for a war-powers resolution seeking to limit Mr Trump's authority to launch further military action against Iran without congressional approval.

The **White House** asked Congress to approve an additional \$87.6bn in **spending**, most of it to cover the war with Iran and replenish munitions. The package also includes money to help contain the [Ebola outbreak](#) in Central Africa and provide additional economic support to [farmers](#). The proposal faces long odds in the Senate, where Democrats oppose funding the war.

Camp Mystic, a summer camp in **Texas** where 28 people died in [catastrophic floods](#) last year, filed for Chapter 11 bankruptcy protection. The camp faces lawsuits from victims' families, who accuse its owners of negligence. State investigators recently concluded that Camp Mystic had inadequate emergency plans and was unprepared for the rapidly rising floodwaters that swept through the site.

Bad blood between Poland and Ukraine



Photograph: Getty Images

The Ukraine Recovery Conference, a now annual summit which began on Thursday, is hosted by Poland this year. It was meant to reaffirm the country's support for its war-torn neighbour. Instead, it will thrust their [testy relationship](#) into the spotlight.

Last month Ukraine named a military unit after the Ukrainian Insurgent Army, a guerilla group accused of massacring some 100,000 Poles during the second world war. After Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, refused to rename the unit, his Polish counterpart, Karol Nawrocki (pictured), stripped him of the Order of the White Eagle, Poland's highest decoration. On Tuesday Mr Zelensky dropped out of the conference, sending Yulia Svyrydenko, his prime minister, in his stead.

It is only the latest skirmish. A row over grain exports in 2023 prompted Poland to suspend weapons deliveries. The fallout from this row may be painful for cash-strapped Ukraine, and is embarrassing for Poland's pro-European government, which is at odds with its hard-right president.

No truce in the fight against inflation



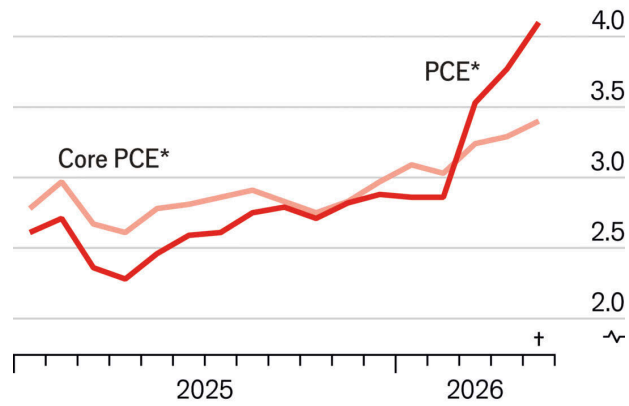
Photograph: EPA

Kevin Warsh revealed little at his first policy meeting as Federal Reserve chair last week. He brushed questions aside with a wry: “We have a task force for that.” Yet investors heard a [hawkish message](#). Mr Warsh insisted that inflation in America remains too high and Fed officials are “unanimous” in their commitment to price stability. Half of the central bank’s policymakers foresaw at least one rate rise this year; six pencilled in two or more. Markets now assign roughly a one-in-three chance of a hike as soon as July.

The next test comes on Thursday, when America’s Bureau of Economic Analysis releases the personal-consumption-expenditures price index for May, the Fed’s preferred inflation gauge. Economists expect headline inflation of 4% over the past year, and core inflation, which strips out food and energy, of 3.4%. A [tentative America-Iran deal](#) is already easing [energy prices](#). But if it frays, Mr Warsh’s task will become clearer: keeping rates high.

Up for the challenge

United States, consumer prices,
% increase on a year earlier



*Personal-consumption expenditures †Forecast

Source: Haver Analytics

A match with Mexican history



Photograph: EPA

King Felipe of Spain travels to Mexico on Thursday for some [football diplomacy](#). Before watching his national team play Uruguay in Guadalajara in the [World Cup](#) he will meet Claudia Sheinbaum, Mexico's president. It is an effort to end seven years of tension between Spain and the largest Spanish-speaking country, both of which have left-of-centre governments.

The trouble began when Ms Sheinbaum's predecessor and mentor, Andrés Manuel López Obrador, demanded that the king apologise for the "abuses" committed five centuries ago by Hernán Cortés and his conquistadors. He was playing domestic politics; some Spaniards suggested tartly that Mr López Obrador, a populist nationalist of Spanish descent, should himself apologise. Visiting an exhibition of Mexican archaeology in Madrid in March, the king admitted there was abuse, without directly apologising, prompting Ms Sheinbaum to invite him: high time to get the ball rolling.

Italy and France's tense friendship



Photograph: David Simonds

Giorgia Meloni, Italy's populist-right prime minister, has not always seen eye-to-eye with Emmanuel Macron, France's centrist president. Among other things she dislikes his preference for getting together with Germany and Britain in the "E3" format, which excludes Italy. But the pair will seek to make amends on Thursday at a mini-summit in Antibes on the Mediterranean. It is the first such gathering since the two countries signed a reinforced friendship treaty five years ago.

The leaders are due to discuss a range of matters, from support to Ukraine and Lebanon to industrial defence co-operation. They will put on a good display of neighbourly friendship, not least after Ms Meloni's recent spat with America's Donald Trump. He claimed that she begged him for a photo at the G7 summit in Evian-les-Bains last week in order to boost her flagging popularity. She retorted on social media that "[being your friend](#) certainly has not helped it". Mr Trump's antics are driving Europeans into each other's arms.

Straight from the horse's mouth



Photograph: Getty Images

What does a finch mean when it chirps? And what is a striped mouse thinking when it squeaks? These are the kinds of questions occupying the finalists of this year's Collier-Dolittle Prize, worth \$100,000—a competition to develop an algorithm for communicating with non-human animals. Set up by Jeremy Collier, a British billionaire investor and animal-welfare activist, the challenge is inspired by the Turing test, which assesses whether machines can think. The winner is announced on Thursday.

Scientists started working seriously on the problem of [animal cognition and communication](#) in the 1960s. But things have really picked up thanks to AI. Researchers can now use large language models to analyse huge audio datasets of grunts and caws to identify patterns. Last year's winners recorded the whistle of a bottlenose dolphin using hydrophones and acoustic tags attached to suction cups. To decode their meaning, they observed the reactions other dolphins had when the recordings were played back at them.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which American oil tycoon haggled with the kidnappers when his grandson was taken in 1973?

Wednesday: Which actor rose to fame playing a modern version of Sherlock Holmes before playing Dr Strange in various Marvel movies?

*Speak across borders even if
borders pass through every word.*

Ingeborg Bachmann